CHURCH MANAGEMENT SYSTEM & MEMBER APP

A comprehensive feature blueprint for church administration, member engagement, ministry operations and scalable growth.

PRODUCT VISION

Build a complete Church Operating System: one connected platform that helps churches manage their people, finances, ministries, services, events and spiritual community.

Recommended product structure

- **Church management platform:** for pastors, administrators, finance teams, department leaders and church workers.
- **Member application:** for members and visitors to access sermons, give, join groups, submit prayer requests and stay connected.
- **Shared church database:** a central source of truth for member records, attendance, finance, departments, events and communication.

Prepared as a product planning document

1. Product structure

The system should have two connected experiences supported by a shared data layer.

Layer	Purpose	Primary users
Admin dashboard	Church operations, reporting, configuration and oversight.	Pastors, administrators, finance officers, department leaders
Member app	Member engagement, spiritual resources, giving and community.	Members, workers and visitors
Shared database	Stores and connects church records with controlled access.	Authorised users and system services

2. Church management dashboard

A. Dashboard overview

The dashboard should show both current figures and trends, such as attendance compared with the previous week or month.

- Total registered members and active members.
- New members, first-time visitors and returning visitors.
- Attendance for the most recent service and attendance trends.
- Tithes, offerings, donations, expenses and outstanding pledges.
- Upcoming services and events.
- Members requiring follow-up.
- Department and cell-group activity summaries.
- Recent administrative activity and important alerts.

B. Member management (CRM)

- Register members and maintain individual profiles with photographs, contact details and residential address.
- Record date joined, membership status, baptism status and date, occupation and relevant demographic details.
- Assign members to branches, departments, cell groups and ministry teams.
- Generate unique member IDs and digital membership cards.
- Store emergency contacts and family relationships, such as spouse, children and parents.
- Search, filter, import and export member records using CSV or Excel.
- Maintain membership history and archive inactive records.
- Send birthday and wedding-anniversary reminders.
- Support new-member onboarding and transfers between branches.

C. Attendance management

- Record attendance for Sunday services, midweek services and special programmes.
- Track attendance by service, branch, department and cell group.
- Register first-time visitors and returning visitors.
- Record children separately where appropriate.
- Support manual check-in, QR-code check-in, member self-check-in and bulk spreadsheet upload.
- View attendance history, compare periods and generate reports.
- Identify attendance patterns and flag members who may need follow-up.

D. Finance management

Finance access must be restricted by role. A department leader should not automatically see all church financial records.

- **Income:** tithes, offerings, donations, building projects, missions, welfare contributions, fundraising, pledges and other income.
- **Expenses:** salaries, utilities, equipment, maintenance, transport, welfare, outreach, departmental and building expenses.
- Record cash, bank transfer and online transactions.
- Generate receipts and track payment references.
- Manage church bank/cash accounts, income categories and expense categories.
- Create budgets and monitor actual spending against budget.
- Track pledges and outstanding balances.
- Generate monthly and annual financial reports, cashbooks and statements.
- Maintain an audit trail of financial actions and approvals.

E. Department and ministry management

- Create departments such as choir, ushering, media, technical, evangelism, prayer, welfare, children, youth, protocol and security.
- Assign department leaders and executives.
- Add or remove members and manage department roles.
- Track department attendance, activities, announcements and events.
- Assign tasks and maintain schedules.
- Manage departmental budgets and generate department-specific reports.

F. Cell groups and house fellowships

- Create groups, assign cell leaders and allocate members.
- Record meeting locations, schedules and attendance.
- Submit cell meeting reports and prayer requests.
- Share group announcements and follow-up tasks.
- Track cell growth and identify groups that may need leadership support.
- Transfer members between groups with a history of changes.

G. Service management

- Create services with dates, times and service types.
- Build service programmes and assign ministers, worship leaders, ushers and scripture readers.
- Manage duty rosters and special assignments.
- Upload service documents and record service reports.
- Track attendance and offerings for each service.

H. Events and programme management

- Create events with descriptions, banners, dates, venues and registration details.
- Set registration limits and manage guest lists.
- Track attendance, volunteers, budgets and expenses.
- Send event reminders and generate event reports.
- Support ticketing where relevant.

I. Communication and announcements

- Send church-wide, branch-specific, department-specific and cell-group announcements.
- Use push notifications, email, SMS and approved WhatsApp integrations.
- Schedule announcements and event reminders.
- Send birthday messages and urgent announcements.
- Maintain delivery history and target only the intended audience.

J. Follow-up and pastoral care

- Manage first-timer, new-member and absentee follow-up.
- Record hospital visits, bereavement support and pastoral visits.
- Receive counselling appointment requests, prayer requests and welfare requests.
- Assign follow-up tasks to workers and track their status.
- Maintain confidential pastoral notes with strict permissions.
- Schedule reminders and record contact attempts.

Example first-time visitor workflow

Step	Action
1. Register	Visitor submits details through the app or a registration form.
2. Create record	System creates a visitor profile and marks it as first-time.
3. Assign	A designated follow-up worker receives a task.
4. Contact	Worker calls or messages the visitor and records the outcome.
5. Track	Church tracks return visits, membership interest and onboarding.

K. Workers and volunteer management

- Worker profiles, departments, roles and responsibilities.
- Worker attendance, availability, duty rosters and service assignments.
- Volunteer applications, training records and leave requests.
- Track participation and generate activity reports.

L. Inventory and asset management

- Register musical instruments, sound equipment, projectors, computers, furniture and vehicles.
- Track asset location, assigned department, condition and maintenance.
- Record purchases, transfers, repairs and disposals.
- Generate asset and maintenance reports.

M. Branch management

- Create branches and assign branch pastors and administrators.
- Maintain branch-specific members, attendance, finance, events and departments.
- Provide headquarters with consolidated reports.
- Compare branch activity while enforcing branch-level permissions.

3. Member application

The member-facing experience should be simple, mobile-first and useful even to visitors who have not yet become members.

A. Member home

- Welcome message and personalised home screen.
- Upcoming services and events.
- Latest church announcements.
- Recent sermons and livestream links.
- Bible verse or devotional of the day.
- Quick access to prayer requests, giving and member profile.

B. Sermons and media library

- Watch recorded sermons and listen to audio messages.
- Search and filter by pastor, topic, date or category.
- Save favourites and continue watching.
- Download media where permitted and share sermon links.
- View sermon notes and access livestreams or podcasts.

C. Bible and spiritual growth

- Bible reading with licensed translations.
- Daily devotionals and structured reading plans.
- Bookmark and highlight scriptures.
- Personal notes and prayer journal.
- Spiritual growth challenges and inspirational messages.

D. Giving and donations

- Give tithes, offerings and donations towards specific projects.
- Fulfil pledges and view private giving history.
- Download receipts and optionally set up recurring giving.
- Show campaign progress where appropriate.
- Consider Nigerian payment integrations such as Paystack or Flutterwave, plus bank transfer recording.

E. Prayer requests and testimonies

- Submit prayer requests with public or private visibility choices.
- Route private requests only to authorised pastoral staff.
- Submit testimonies and allow the church to approve items before public sharing.
- Receive updates where appropriate.

F. Church community

- Member directory with privacy controls.
- Join cell groups and view department activities.
- Participate in moderated group discussions.
- Share approved testimonies and encouragement.

- View church announcements and community events.

G. Member profile

- Update personal details and profile photo.
- View membership status, branch, department and cell group.
- View personal attendance and giving history.
- See upcoming assignments and manage notification preferences.
- Request a branch or group change.

H. Visitor experience

- View church information, location and service schedules.
- Plan a visit and register as a first-time visitor.
- Watch public sermons and submit prayer requests.
- Contact the church and learn how to become a member.
- Allow basic visitor access without requiring full membership registration.

4. Advanced and differentiating features

Feature	Purpose
AI church assistant	Answers questions using approved church information, schedules and resources.
AI sermon assistant	Creates sermon summaries, discussion questions and takeaways from uploaded material.
Attendance insights	Highlights attendance trends and possible follow-up needs.
Automated workflows	Assigns tasks after visitor registration, missed attendance or submitted requests.
Digital membership card	Provides a unique member identity card.
QR attendance	Speeds up service check-in.
Church website builder	Lets a church manage its public website content.
Counselling booking	Allows members to request available appointment slots.
Room and equipment booking	Manages halls, meeting rooms and shared equipment.
Church academy	Supports membership, discipleship and workers' training courses.
Livestream integration	Connects live services and recorded broadcasts.
Financial forecasting	Compares income and expenditure against budgets.
Church analytics	Combines growth, attendance, giving and engagement reporting.

5. User roles and permissions

Use role-based access control (RBAC), with configurable permissions and scope. Access should be limited to the church, branch, department or records relevant to each role.

Role	Typical access
Super Admin	Full platform configuration and organisation-wide access.
Senior Pastor	Church-wide overview and pastoral oversight.
Church Administrator	Members, services, events and operations.

Role	Typical access
Finance Officer	Income, expenses, budgets, receipts and financial reports.
Branch Pastor	Management and oversight of an assigned branch.
Department Leader	Members, activities and schedules for their department.
Cell Leader	Members, attendance and activities for their cell group.
Follow-up Officer	Visitor and follow-up records assigned to them.
Usher	Service attendance and visitor registration.
Member	Own profile and permitted member features.
Visitor	Public church information and visitor features.

6. Additional management modules

Module	Possible capabilities
Staff management	Staff profiles, employment records, payroll, leave and salary history.
Welfare management	Applications, approvals, beneficiaries and disbursement records.
Counselling management	Appointments, counsellor assignment and confidential records.
Discipleship management	Membership classes, baptism classes, foundations courses and completion tracking.
Children's ministry	Guardian details, class assignments and secure child check-in/check-out.
Marriage management	Marriage counselling, wedding requests and anniversary records.
Missions and outreach	Outreach planning, volunteers, locations, expenses and impact reports.
Document management	Policies, meeting minutes, reports, certificates and important documents.
Meeting management	Leadership meetings, attendance, minutes and assigned action points.

7. Recommended admin navigation

Navigation item	What it contains
Overview	Church-wide dashboard and alerts.
Members	Member directory, profiles, visitor records and onboarding.
Attendance & Services	Service setup, check-in, attendance and service reports.
Finance	Income, expenses, pledges, budgets, receipts and statements.
Departments & Cell Groups	Teams, leaders, group members, meetings and reports.
Follow-up & Pastoral Care	Visitor follow-up, care requests, visits and counselling requests.
Events & Programmes	Event creation, registration, volunteers and reporting.
Communication	Announcements, notifications and delivery history.
Workers & Volunteers	Worker profiles, rosters, availability and training.
Assets & Inventory	Equipment register, locations and maintenance.
Branches	Branch setup, branch teams and consolidated reporting.
Reports & Analytics	Operational, attendance, membership and financial reports.
Settings	Roles, permissions, integrations, templates and organisation settings.

8. MVP and development roadmap

Do not build every module at once. Start with the operational workflows that churches need most, then add member engagement and advanced capabilities.

Phase 1 — Essential MVP

Module	Initial scope
Dashboard	Members, attendance, income and upcoming events.
Members	Registration, profiles, search and categorisation.
Attendance	Service attendance and visitor tracking.
Finance	Income, expenses, receipts and basic reports.
Departments	Create departments, assign leaders and members.
Events	Create events and manage registrations.
Communication	Announcements and notifications.
Follow-up	First-timer and absentee follow-up.
Roles	Admin, pastor, finance officer and department leader.

Phase 2 — Member engagement

- Member-facing mobile-friendly application.
- Digital membership cards and QR check-in.
- Sermon library, online giving and livestream links.
- Prayer requests, testimonies and cell groups.

- Bible resources, devotionals and push notifications.

Phase 3 — Advanced management

- Multi-branch management and consolidated reporting.
- Payroll, staff management, inventory and asset management.
- Welfare and counselling workflows.
- Church academy and training management.
- AI assistant, advanced analytics and automated workflows.

9. Product and technical decisions

A. Multi-tenant architecture

- If the product will serve multiple churches, each church must have an isolated workspace and data boundary.
- A church should only access its own members, finance, departments and records.
- The same software can serve many churches without exposing one church's data to another.

Example: Grace Assembly and Living Faith use the same product, but each has separate users, member records, finances, departments and settings.

B. Multi-branch support

- Support a single-branch church as well as a church with many branches.
- Allow branch-level administration and headquarters-level oversight.
- Apply branch-specific access controls to member, finance and operational records.

C. Audit logs and approvals

- Record who created, edited, approved or deleted important records.
- Use approval workflows for sensitive actions such as expenses, refunds and financial adjustments.
- Keep transaction history rather than silently overwriting financial records.

D. Privacy and security

- Use least-privilege permissions and secure authentication.
- Protect prayer requests, counselling records, children's information and financial data.
- Collect only necessary personal data and obtain appropriate consent.
- Provide data retention, export and deletion processes aligned with applicable privacy laws, including Nigeria's NDPA.
- Use backups, monitoring and secure handling of payment references.

E. Mobile-first experience

- Make the member experience easy to use on smartphones.
- Ensure the admin dashboard works well on desktop, tablet and mobile.
- Design for intermittent connectivity where practical, especially for attendance capture.

10. Recommended product positioning

Position the product as a **Church Operating System**, rather than only a church app.

Core value proposition

Everything your church needs to manage its people, finances, ministries, services and spiritual community in one place.

Potential customer segments

- Small churches that need simple administration and member records.
- Medium-sized churches that need departments, finance and attendance management.
- Large churches that need complex permissions, multiple branches and consolidated reporting.

A subscription model can scale by church size, number of branches, number of members or access to advanced modules. Keep essential workflows available in every plan and reserve genuinely advanced capabilities for higher tiers.

11. Recommended next step

Before development, confirm the product's intended audience, platforms and initial scope. These decisions affect tenancy, permissions, database structure, onboarding and pricing.

Decision	Recommended starting point
Audience	Multi-church SaaS, unless this is for one specific church.
Platforms	Web admin dashboard plus a responsive member-facing application.
Product ambition	Complete ecosystem, delivered in phases.
Church size	Scalable from small churches to multi-branch organisations.

The practical next deliverable should be a product requirements document (PRD), followed by user flows, database schema, permission matrix, API design and an MVP development plan.